

BONUS GUIDE

Start Your **Drywall** **Business** in 30 Days

A week-by-week action plan to go from skilled
tradesperson to profitable business owner

DRYWALL PRO

Why Drywall Is a Great Trade Business

If you already have drywall skills, you are sitting on one of the most accessible and profitable trade businesses you can start.

Low Startup Costs

Unlike plumbing or electrical work, drywall requires relatively inexpensive tools. You can get started with a basic kit for **\$500 to \$2,000**. No heavy machinery, no expensive certifications. Your skills are your biggest asset.

Constant, Year-Round Demand

Every new construction project needs drywall. Every renovation, every remodel, every water-damage repair. Drywall work is needed in residential, commercial, and industrial settings. It is **recession-resistant** because even when new builds slow down, repairs and renovations continue.

Highly Scalable

Start as a solo operator, add a helper when you are busy, then grow to a full crew. You control the pace. Many drywall business owners go from solo to running a crew of 4+ within their first two years.

The opportunity is real: According to industry data, the average drywall contractor earns between \$50,000 and \$80,000 per year as a solo operator. With a small crew, that number can exceed \$150,000. This guide gives you the exact steps to get there.

What You Need to Start

- ▶ **Drywall skills** (hanging, taping, finishing, or all three)
- ▶ **Basic tools** you probably already own
- ▶ **Reliable transportation** (truck or van)
- ▶ **A willingness to hustle** for your first few jobs
- ▶ **30 days of focused action** following this plan

The next four chapters break down your launch into weekly milestones. Each week ends with a day-by-day checklist so nothing falls through the cracks. Let's get to work.

WEEK 1 — DAYS 1-7

Business Setup

This week you lay the legal and financial foundation. Do it right now so you never have to redo it later.

Choose Your Business Structure

Most new drywall contractors choose between two structures. Here is how they compare:

FACTOR	SOLE PROPRIETORSHIP	LLC
Setup cost	Free (just your name)	\$50 – \$500 (varies by state)
Personal liability	You are personally liable	Business assets are separate
Taxes	Pass-through (Schedule C)	Pass-through (more flexibility)
Credibility	Less formal	Looks more professional to GCs
Best for	Testing the waters	Serious about growing

Recommendation: Form an LLC. It costs a little more upfront but protects your personal assets and makes you look professional to general contractors. Most states let you file online in 15 minutes.

Get Your EIN (Employer Identification Number)

Apply for a free EIN at irs.gov. It takes about 5 minutes online. You will need this for your business bank account, taxes, and hiring. Think of it as your business's Social Security number.

Open a Business Bank Account

This is non-negotiable. **Never mix personal and business finances.** Bring your EIN and LLC paperwork to any bank. Look for an account with no monthly fees or low minimums. Many banks offer free business checking for small businesses.

Set Up Basic Bookkeeping

Choose one tool and stick with it from day one:

- ▶ **Wave Accounting** — Free, handles invoicing and expenses
- ▶ **QuickBooks Self-Employed** — \$15/month, great for tracking mileage and taxes
- ▶ **A simple spreadsheet** — Works if you are disciplined about updating it

WEEK 1 — DAY-BY-DAY ACTION CHECKLIST

- ☐ **Day 1:** Research LLC filing requirements in your state
- ☐ **Day 2:** File your LLC online (or register your sole proprietorship)
- ☐ **Day 3:** Apply for your EIN on irs.gov
- ☐ **Day 4:** Open a business bank account
- ☐ **Day 5:** Set up Wave or QuickBooks; link your business account
- ☐ **Day 6:** Order business checks; set up a dedicated business phone number
- ☐ **Day 7:** Review everything — all accounts active, EIN on file, bookkeeping ready

WEEK 2 — DAYS 8-14

Insurance & Licensing

Before you take your first paid job, get properly insured and licensed. This protects you and makes you hireable by general contractors.

General Liability Insurance

This is your **most important insurance**. It covers property damage and injuries on the job site. Most general contractors will not hire you without it.

Typical cost: \$400 – \$800 per year for a solo drywall contractor. Get at least \$1 million in coverage. Shop quotes from at least 3 providers. Many insurers offer online quotes in minutes.

Workers' Compensation Insurance

Required in most states as soon as you hire your first employee. Even if you start solo, know your state's requirements. Some states require it even for sole proprietors in construction trades. Cost varies based on payroll, but expect **\$3 – \$5 per \$100 of payroll** for drywall work.

Commercial Auto Insurance

If you use your vehicle for business (hauling materials, driving to job sites), your personal auto policy may not cover accidents during work use. A commercial auto policy fills that gap. Add it to your general liability policy for a bundled discount.

Local Business License & Permits

Requirements vary by city and county. Check with your local city hall or county clerk's office. Most jurisdictions require a general business license at minimum. Some require a home occupation permit if you run the business from home.

Contractor License Requirements

Contractor licensing varies significantly by state:

- ▶ **Some states** require a specific drywall or general contractor license
- ▶ **Some states** only require registration (no exam)
- ▶ **Some states** have no state-level requirement but counties/cities do

Research your specific state's requirements early so you have time to complete any exams or applications.

Bonding

Some clients and jurisdictions require a surety bond. This guarantees you will complete the work. A **\$10,000 bond typically costs \$100 – \$300 per year**. Not always required, but having one adds credibility.

WEEK 2 — DAY-BY-DAY ACTION CHECKLIST

- ☐ **Day 8:** Get 3 quotes for general liability insurance
- ☐ **Day 9:** Choose and purchase your general liability policy
- ☐ **Day 10:** Research workers' comp requirements in your state
- ☐ **Day 11:** Look into commercial auto insurance; get quotes
- ☐ **Day 12:** Visit city hall or go online for your local business license
- ☐ **Day 13:** Research state contractor license requirements; start application if needed
- ☐ **Day 14:** Obtain bonding if required; organize all insurance certificates in one folder

WEEK 3 — DAYS 15-21

Marketing & Finding Clients

You do not need a big budget to get your first clients. You need a strategy, consistency, and the right channels.

Build Relationships with General Contractors

This is your **number one source of work**. GCs need reliable drywall subs. Here is how to get on their radar:

- ▶ Visit active job sites and introduce yourself to the site foreman
- ▶ Attend local builder association meetings
- ▶ Ask your supply house who is buying materials (they know the active GCs)
- ▶ Start with one or two GCs; deliver excellent work and reliability
- ▶ Always have your insurance certificate ready to hand over

Pro tip: GCs value reliability over price. Show up on time, finish when you say you will, clean up after yourself, and answer your phone. Do this consistently and you will have more work than you can handle.

Free and Low-Cost Marketing Channels

Google Business Profile (Free)

Create your listing at **business.google.com**. This is essential for appearing in local searches like "drywall contractor near me." Add photos of your work, your service area, and your hours. This alone can generate steady leads once you get a few reviews.

Nextdoor (Free)

Claim your business on Nextdoor. Neighbors recommend contractors here all the time. Respond to posts where people ask for drywall help.

Facebook Business Page + Local Groups (Free)

Create a simple business page with your logo, photos of completed work, and your service area. Join local community groups and homeowner groups. Be helpful, not salesy. When someone asks for a drywall recommendation, you want to be top of mind.

Simple Website or Landing Page (\$0 – \$20/month)

You do not need an expensive website. A single-page site with your services, service area, a few photos, and a way to request a quote is enough. Free options include Google Sites or a simple one-page builder.

Physical Marketing

- ▶ **Yard signs** — Place at job sites (with permission). \$5–\$15 each.
- ▶ **Vehicle magnets** — Your truck becomes a billboard. \$30–\$60 for a pair.
- ▶ **Business cards** — Keep them in your truck, at supply houses, and on every job.

Word of Mouth Strategy

Ask every satisfied customer: "Do you know anyone else who needs drywall work?" Offer a small referral bonus (\$25–\$50) for leads that turn into jobs. This is the most cost-effective marketing that exists.

WEEK 3 — DAY-BY-DAY ACTION CHECKLIST

- ☐ **Day 15:** Create your Google Business Profile
- ☐ **Day 16:** Set up a Facebook business page with 5+ photos of past work
- ☐ **Day 17:** Claim your Nextdoor business page
- ☐ **Day 18:** Visit 2–3 active job sites and introduce yourself to GCs
- ☐ **Day 19:** Order yard signs, vehicle magnets, and business cards
- ☐ **Day 20:** Set up a simple website or landing page
- ☐ **Day 21:** Visit your local supply house; ask about busy GCs in the area

WEEK 4 — DAYS 22–30

First Jobs & Cash Flow

Time to land your first jobs and set up systems that keep the money flowing.

How to Price Your First Jobs

Pricing is where most new contractors struggle. Here is a framework:

SERVICE	TYPICAL RATE RANGE	NOTES
Hang only	\$0.25 – \$0.45 / sq ft	Board hanging without finishing
Tape & finish only	\$0.35 – \$0.60 / sq ft	Level 4 or Level 5 finish
Hang + tape + finish	\$0.65 – \$1.20 / sq ft	Complete drywall package
Patch / repair	\$150 – \$400+ per job	Higher margin, smaller jobs
Texture application	\$0.30 – \$0.60 / sq ft	Knockdown, orange peel, etc.

Pricing tip: For your first 3–5 jobs, price slightly below market to win the work and build your portfolio. But never price so low that you lose money. Always calculate your material cost, labor time, and overhead before quoting.

Creating Professional Estimates

A good estimate builds trust and wins jobs. Every estimate should include:

- ▶ Your business name, address, and license/insurance info
- ▶ Detailed scope of work (what is included and what is not)
- ▶ Material specifications
- ▶ Total price with payment terms
- ▶ Estimated timeline
- ▶ Validity period (typically 30 days)

Invoicing & Getting Paid

Payment on Completion

- Best for residential jobs
- Get paid as soon as you finish
- Collect a 50% deposit upfront for materials
- Balance due upon completion

Net 30 (Commercial / GC Work)

- Standard for subcontractor work
- Invoice upon completion
- Payment within 30 days
- Requires cash reserves to cover the gap

Building a Referral System

After every completed job:

1. Ask if the client is happy with the work
2. Request a Google review (hand them your phone if needed)
3. Ask if they know anyone else who needs drywall work
4. Leave 2–3 business cards
5. Follow up in 2 weeks with a thank-you message

WEEK 4 — DAY-BY-DAY ACTION CHECKLIST

- ☐ **Day 22:** Create an estimate template in Word, Google Docs, or your invoicing tool
- ☐ **Day 23:** Set up invoicing in Wave or QuickBooks
- ☐ **Day 24:** Research local market rates; call 2–3 competitors for quotes
- ☐ **Day 25:** Follow up on all GC contacts from Week 3
- ☐ **Day 26:** Bid on your first 2–3 jobs
- ☐ **Day 27:** Prepare materials and schedule for your first job
- ☐ **Day 28–29:** Complete your first job with excellent quality
- ☐ **Day 30:** Collect payment, request a review, ask for referrals

Essential Business Tools

You do not need expensive software. Start with the basics and add tools as you grow.

CATEGORY	TOOL	COST	WHY YOU NEED IT
Accounting	Wave / QuickBooks	Free – \$15/mo	Track income, expenses, and taxes
Scheduling	Jobber / Housecall Pro	\$30 – \$50/mo	Manage jobs, schedules, and dispatching
CRM	Spreadsheet / Jobber	Free – \$30/mo	Track leads, follow-ups, and client history
Estimates	Jobber / Buildertrend	Free – \$50/mo	Professional-looking estimates in minutes
Documentation	Your smartphone	Free	Before/after photos for every job

Start lean: At minimum, use Wave (free) for accounting and your phone for photos. Add scheduling software when you start managing 3+ jobs per week. A simple spreadsheet with client names, dates, and job details works as your first CRM.

Photo Documentation Best Practices

Take photos at every stage of every job. This habit pays for itself in multiple ways:

- ▶ **Before photos** protect you from pre-existing damage claims
- ▶ **Progress photos** show your craftsmanship for marketing
- ▶ **Completed photos** become your portfolio for winning future jobs
- ▶ **Issue documentation** provides evidence if disputes arise

Create a simple folder system on your phone: one folder per client, named with the date and address.

Scaling: From Solo to Crew

Once you are consistently busy, it is time to think about growing. Here is how to scale smart.

When to Hire Your First Helper

You are ready to hire when:

- ▶ You are turning down work because you cannot keep up
- ▶ You have 4+ weeks of scheduled jobs ahead
- ▶ Your cash flow can support payroll for at least 2 months
- ▶ You are spending too much time on tasks a helper could handle

Employee vs. Subcontractor

FACTOR	W-2 EMPLOYEE	1099 SUBCONTRACTOR
Control	You direct how, when, where	They control their own methods
Taxes	You withhold and pay employer taxes	They handle their own taxes
Insurance	You provide workers' comp	They carry their own insurance
Flexibility	More loyal, available consistently	Easier to scale up and down
Risk	Higher fixed costs	IRS misclassification risk

Important: The IRS takes worker classification seriously. If you tell someone when to show up, what tools to use, and how to do the work, they are likely an employee, not a subcontractor. Misclassification can result in back taxes and penalties. When in doubt, consult a tax professional.

Training New Hires

- ▶ Start them on simple tasks: carrying board, cleanup, basic hanging
- ▶ Teach your quality standards from day one
- ▶ Inspect their work closely for the first 2–4 weeks
- ▶ Gradually increase responsibility as they prove themselves

Managing Multiple Jobs

As you scale, organization becomes critical:

- ▶ Use a scheduling tool to avoid double-booking
- ▶ Pre-order materials 2–3 days before each job
- ▶ Visit each job site daily, even if just for 15 minutes
- ▶ Communicate timeline updates to GCs and clients proactively
- ▶ Delegate execution but never delegate quality control

Income Projections

Here is what you can realistically expect to earn at each stage of growth.

BUSINESS STAGE	ANNUAL REVENUE	EST. PROFIT (AFTER EXPENSES)	NOTES
Solo operator	\$70K – \$110K	\$50K – \$80K	Low overhead, high margins
Solo + 1 helper	\$110K – \$180K	\$70K – \$120K	Double output, shared labor costs
Small crew (3–4)	\$200K – \$400K	\$100K – \$200K+	Multiple jobs running simultaneously
Established company	\$400K – \$1M+	\$150K – \$350K+	Full crews, commercial contracts

Revenue vs. Profit Breakdown

Understanding where your money goes is essential for profitability:

EXPENSE CATEGORY	% OF REVENUE	DETAILS
Materials	20% – 30%	Drywall, mud, tape, screws, corner bead
Labor (if applicable)	25% – 40%	Wages, payroll taxes, workers' comp
Insurance	3% – 5%	GL, auto, workers' comp
Vehicle / fuel	5% – 8%	Gas, maintenance, payments
Tools & equipment	2% – 5%	Replacements and upgrades
Marketing	1% – 3%	Signs, cards, website, ads
Net profit (solo)	55% – 70%	Your take-home before taxes

Seasonal Considerations

Drywall work tends to be steady year-round, but keep these patterns in mind:

- ▶ **Spring/summer:** Peak season for residential new construction and renovations
- ▶ **Fall:** Strong demand from homeowners preparing before winter
- ▶ **Winter:** Interior work continues; commercial projects often ramp up

- ▶ **Slow periods:** Use downtime for marketing, training, and equipment maintenance

Cash flow tip: Save 3 months of operating expenses as a buffer. Drywall is less seasonal than exterior trades, but having reserves lets you turn down low-margin work and wait for better-paying jobs.

NEXT STEP

Your 30-Day Clock Starts Now

You have the plan. You have the skills. The difference between a tradesperson and a business owner is action.

Open this guide to Week 1, Day 1. Complete one task today. Then do the next one tomorrow. In 30 days, you will have a fully set up, properly insured, actively marketed drywall business with your first jobs on the calendar.

The best time to start was yesterday. The second best time is right now.

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